

The Tanuki's Tidy-Up

The blossom mountains of Yamato rise in soft green folds above terraced rice fields and little villages strung with paper lanterns, where cherry trees drop their petals on the wind and red torii gates mark the quiet shrines. Mist drifts among the bamboo, the moon lays a silver path on the river, and the hills are full of gentle spirits: a riddling fox, shy fireflies who light the lanterns, a jolly trickster tanuki, stone guardian dogs, and a great old river dragon who brings the rains. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is patient, thinks things through, and is kind to every living thing. The grandest deeds are done with imagination and courage and a gentle heart, and even a fearsome guardian, met with a calm and friendly word, often turns out kinder than it looks.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.

★ *Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only kinder ideas to try.*

Before you begin

It was festival day in the Lantern Village, the brightest day of the whole year. All morning the market had been getting ready: stalls of painted paper fans, baskets heaped with plums and pears and golden persimmons, and long rows of paper lanterns waiting to glow. Cherry petals drifted on the breeze, and everyone hummed with excitement.

Nobody hummed more than Pon the Tanuki. He was so happy, so round, and so very bouncy, that he simply could not keep still. He rolled. He bounced. He tumbled head over heels right down the middle of the market, and one by one, every single stall went over with a clatter. When the dust settled, the fans, the fruit, and the lanterns lay in one enormous jumble, and poor Pon sat in the middle of it with his ears flat and his heart full of sorry.

Granny Yuki the Tale-Keeper, who knew every story in the mountains, called the two of you to her side. "You have heads full of ideas and kind hearts," she said, "and that is worth more today than the strongest pair of arms. Will you help Pon set the market right before the festival opens?"

Into your hands she pressed three gifts: a ball of bright red thread, a little bronze bell, and a soft, sweet rice cake. "Remember," she said with a smile, "in these mountains we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being brave, kind, and full of ideas."

★ *What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Imagination, Courage, or Kindness?*

Stop 1 The Jumbled Stalls

You hurried to the market square, and there in the very middle of the muddle sat Pon the Tanuki. His ears drooped. His round nose wobbled. A fat tear sat ready to fall. "I have spoiled the whole festival," he sniffed. "I only ever wanted to help, and I have made everything worse."

He was so sad and so flustered that he could not have tidied a single fan. Before any sorting could begin, Pon needed a friend.

★ *What could you do to help Pon feel better? You might sit down beside him, or tell him that everybody knocks things over sometimes, or remind him that a muddle is much smaller when friends fix it together. What do you try?*

When your kind words reached him, Pon wiped his nose on the back of his paw and gave a small, brave smile. "You are good friends to me," he said. "A muddle is not so big after all. Come on, let us tidy up together." And up he jumped, ready to put right every single thing.

Stop 2 The Great Sort

Now you looked properly at the heap, and what a heap it was. Fans, fruit, and lanterns lay all tangled together in one great mountain of muddle, and every last thing had to find its proper home before the festival could open.

The painted fans belonged, fanned out in their neat rows, on the fan stall. The plums and pears and persimmons belonged sorted into their baskets on the fruit stall. The paper lanterns belonged, one by one, upon the lantern posts that lined the square. To set it right you would have to sort, and count, and match, with calm and careful heads.



How will you bring order to all this? You might make a separate pile for each kind of thing, or count the right number of lanterns onto each post, or match every fruit to its basket by its colour. What is your plan?

Patiently, piece by piece, you sorted and counted it all back into place, and slowly the market grew tidy and bright again. Pon watched in wonder and clapped his small paws together. "You are so full of ideas and so calm," he said. "I would have rushed and made it worse, but you thought it all the way through."

Stop 3 The Last Lantern

The market looked almost perfect now, every fan and fruit and lantern in its place. Almost. For when you looked up at the heart of the square, you saw that the grandest lantern of all was missing: the big red festival lantern that hung high over the very middle, the one whose glow was the signal for the festival to begin. Without it, the drum could not sound.

Just then, Kon the Fox came trotting out of the bamboo with a leaf upon his head and a bright twinkle in his eye. "I am rather good at noticing things," he said. "And I do believe I saw something round and red go rolling away, down the lane, under the old plum tree by the bridge. Follow my clue, and think where a runaway lantern likes to hide."



Where could the last lantern have rolled to? You might follow Kon's clue to the plum tree, or ask Pon, who knows every corner of the market, to help you search. And how will you help Pon feel proud instead of ashamed? What do you do?

You followed the clue down the lane, and there, snug under the drooping plum tree, sat the great red lantern, quite unharmed. As you lifted it up, Pon came bounding over, and it was Pon who pointed out the very branch it had caught on. "I knew where it would roll," he said, and for the first time all day he stood up tall and proud. "I helped after all." Together you carried the lantern back and hung it high in its rightful place.

The Festival Opens

The market was set right at last, and oh, how it shone. Every fan was fanned in its row, every basket of fruit sat neat and gleaming, and every paper lantern glowed warm and golden in its place, with the great red festival lantern burning brightest of all in the very middle of the square.

Pon the Tanuki was forgiven, and far better than forgiven, he was proud. The big drum began to beat, the villagers came laughing and dancing into the square, and with a happy ring the festival opened at last.

High above the blossom mountains, Amaterasu the Sun-Kami looked down through the warm light and smiled. You had done it, and you had done it together: with your imagination, with your courage, and above all with your kindness. Well done, heroes of the Lantern Village.

The Tanuki's Tidy-Up: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

The Guide for the Grown-Up explains how the whole game works. This page holds only what is special about this story. This is a gentle, warm tale with no villain at all: the only trouble is a happy muddle, and imagination and kindness set it right every time. A failed roll is never a defeat; nobody loses.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Lantern Village market.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Kindness** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a ball of string for the red thread, a small bell or jingly thing for the little bell, and any small treat or token for the rice cake. Anything can be anything.
- A handful of buttons, coins, or bricks in two or three colours makes the sorting in Stop 2 lovely and hands-on. It is not needed, but it helps.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

The Twist of Fate

Once at each place the players may roll for a twist; read the matching line. The Guide explains how it works.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Kon the Fox trots by and gives you one free hint.
2	You gather your calm again, and take back one energy star.
3	A soft breeze drifts through, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Guardian Lion-Dogs nod kindly from the gate. All is well.
5	A lucky cherry petal floats down: keep one roll to use again later.
6	The soft ring of a temple bell, and for a moment everyone feels calm.

How it ends

There is no foe in this tale at all. The trouble is only a friendly muddle made by Pon the Tanuki, who feels dreadful about it and most needs a kind word. The story is won by calming and reassuring Pon, by patiently sorting and counting the market back into place, and by helping Pon end the day proud rather than ashamed. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The Tanuki's Tidy-Up: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward kindness and imagination over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Jumbled Stalls (Easy)

The challenge. Pon the Tanuki sits in the middle of the toppled market, too upset and flustered to help. He has knocked everything over by accident and feels he has spoiled the festival. Before any tidying can begin, the players must calm and reassure him.

Intended solution. This is a moment of Kindness and Observation. The players notice that Pon is not naughty, only sad, and offer comfort: sitting beside him, telling him it was an accident, reminding him that everyone topples things sometimes, or promising that the muddle is smaller when friends fix it together. Sharing the rice cake works beautifully too. Any genuine kindness lifts his ears and gets him on his feet.

Fallback. If the children are unsure what to say, have Pon sniffle and ask, very quietly, "Do you think I am a bad tanuki?" A single warm "no" melts the worry at once. A friendly pat or a shared rice cake also does the trick, and Pon springs up, ready to help.

Make it simpler. For a very little one, just ask them to give Pon a big gentle hug and say "it's all right," and his ears perk straight up.

Stop 2: The Great Sort (Normal)

The challenge. Fans, fruit, and lanterns lie jumbled in one big heap. The players must sort, count, and match everything back to the right stall before the festival opens.

Intended solution. This is a Maths, Logic, and Observation moment. The thoughtful move is to sort by kind first, then count and match. A worked example to guide them: make three piles, one for fans, one for fruit, one for lanterns. Fan out the fans on the fan stall. Sort the fruit by colour, the red plums into the red basket and the golden persimmons into the gold basket. Then count the lanterns onto the posts, the same number on each, say three posts with four lanterns each, twelve lanterns in all. Counting aloud together is the heart of this stop. Use buttons or bricks in colours if you have them, so small hands can sort for real.

Fallback. If the counting wobbles, do one pile together out loud and let them copy the pattern for the rest, or let Pon "remember" where one kind of thing goes. Spending an energy star to take a calm breath and start the pile again always works. Getting the market tidy with help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Make it simpler. For a very little one, hand them just the red things and ask them to pop them all in one basket, and that one tidy pile is a win.

Stop 3: The Last Lantern (Normal)

The challenge. The market is nearly perfect, but the big red festival lantern that hangs over the centre is still missing, and the festival cannot begin without it. The players must follow a clue to find it, and help Pon feel proud rather than ashamed.

Intended solution. This is an Imagination and Kindness moment. **Kon the Fox** offers the clue: something round and red rolled away, down the lane, under the old plum tree by the bridge. The thoughtful players follow the clue and think where a runaway lantern likes to hide, and there it is, safe under the tree. Just as important, they let Pon join the search and be the one to spot the branch it caught on, so the day ends with Pon proud of helping rather than sorry for the muddle.

Fallback. If the clue is too tricky, have Kon make it plainer ("look low, near water, where the plums grow"), or let Pon catch a glimpse of red himself. However the lantern is found, make sure Pon gets the credit for the finding, so he ends the story standing tall.

Make it simpler. For a very little one, hide a red toy or ball nearby and let them toddle over and find it, then cheer that they saved the festival.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser, and there never was a foe. When the last lantern is hung, the whole market glows, Pon the Tanuki is forgiven and proud, the drum beats and the festival opens, and **Amaterasu the Sun-Kami** smiles down from the warm sky. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, kind, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

Content licence: CC BY-SA 4.0 (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/>)

Version 4.1, updated 2026-06-05, en-GB



Scan for the latest version

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.